OATH AFRICA 042916-5837

DRAGO

Bernadette Arakwiye

(ah-rah-KWEE-yay)

Minister of Environment
Republic of Rwanda

Addressed as: **Honorable Minister** | Office held since: **July 2025**

Dr. Bernadette Arakwiye is a conservation scientist whose overriding focus on data-driven implementation and just environmental policies defines her approach to leadership.

- **Action-Oriented**
  Arakwiye, who spent years designing restoration and monitoring programs, is fixated on obtaining hard evidence of progress, backed by rigorous science and data. She is skeptical of donors and counterparts who make empty pledges; they "often don't even know where the trees are growing."

- **Mission-Driven**
  Arakwiye evinces a deep sense of urgency, reminding audiences that"we can continue with incremental progress while the planet burns, or we can rise to meet the scale of this crisis." At an international conference last year, she urged an "end to humanity's war on nature."

The Minister is a role model for Rwandan science students, especially young women and girls. Early in her career, she was one of two female students involved in a mountain gorilla survey—inspiring her to help other women to "not be afraid of the forest" and "stay motivated and find a way to improve yourself."

WHY THEY MATTER

Arakwiye controls the environmental policy levers that foreign agriculture and carbon companies must navigate to operate in Rwanda.

- **A Call To Action**
  Arakwiye implores Rwanda's partners to "engage boldly, challenge assumptions, and identify politics and investments that can unlock meaningful progress." She has stressed that the gap between ambition and available finance is in the trillions, not billions.

- **A Climate-Smart Model**
  The Minister wants to position Rwanda as the ideal destination for green investment. She focuses on cross-sectoral restoration and sustainable agriculture, shifting the narrative from simply "planting" trees to "nurturing" them.

Arakwiye has prioritized social equity in carbon projects, mandating that 30 percent of revenue from land-based carbon projects must be shared with local farmers and communities.

OATH AFRICA 042916-5837

DRAGO

MEETING WITH THEM

Arakwiye employs a clear, accessible, and authoritative speaking style, building rapport through shared challenges and lived experiences.

- **Moral Imperatives**
  There's a consistent ethical dimension to her interactions, emphasizing justice, dignity, and shared responsibilities. Arakwiye wants her counterparts to join her, underscoring that “financing Africa's climate priorities is not charity but an investment in our shared future.”

- **Human Consequences**
  Arakwiye routinely reframes conversations to highlight the effect on individuals and communities. In a 2021 interview, she said “I always remember that at the end of the day it's real people like me that will be impacted.”

The Minister speaks as if she is still working through a problem. It reflects her training and curiosity: starting a point, pausing, backing up, adding context, and then returning to the subject at hand. She’ll occasionally admit "that's something I'm still trying to figure out."

ON THEIR MIND

- **New Carbon Fee Structure**
  The Ministry in January released its official Public Notice, establishing the new fee structure for carbon market activities in Rwanda.

- **Parliamentary Summons**
  The Chamber of Deputies in December summoned the Minister of Environment to address land use issues raised during nationwide field visits in 237 sectors across all districts.

- **Biodiversity Finance Fund**
  Rwanda in November launched the Biodiversity Finance Fund, a financing window designed to mobilize resources for ecosystem protection, restoration, and sustainable livelihoods.

- **New Nationally Determined Contribution (NDC) Plan**
  Rwanda in November also released NDC 3.0, outlining climate actions for the period 2025–2035. This includes $7 billion for climate adaptation measures and $4.9 billion to support mitigation efforts to reduce greenhouse gas emissions.

OATH AFRICA 042916-5837

DRAGO

NETWORK

Arakwiye has strong ties to the United States and is slowly building her international network through global conferences and courtesy calls.

Arakwiye's affinity for the United States reflects her years as a graduate student there, living in New Hampshire and Massachusetts. Her network has grown since her appointment, representing Rwanda at COP30, the United Nations Environment Assembly, and the Africa Climate Summit, as well as serving as keynote speaker at the 6th World Congress on Agroforestry in Kigali.

Arakwiye appears to have a professional relationship with President Kagame and a positive working partnership with Ministry Permanent Secretary Fidèle Bingwa.

While there is limited reporting on her relations with both men, it is notable that President Kagame appointed Arakwiye and Permanent Secretary Bingwa within a week of each other. This suggests that Kagame may have selected them as a unified leadership team to overhaul the ministry.

CONTROVERSIES

While Arakwiye has a clean record regarding her personal conduct, there have been legislative inquiries into some of the Ministry's policies and tensions with local communities near recently restored Kigali wetlands.

- **Land Use Queries**
  Rwanda's Chamber of Deputies summoned Arakwiye and the Minister of Infrastructure in December to explain several issues, including why residents are holding documents classifying their land as residential, but according to master plans, they are designated for agriculture.

- **Wetlands Management**
  The Minister has lectured residents to stop dumping waste near the restored Kigali wetlands. She told them that water filtration systems only work if residents stop polluting the "shared public asset."

Arakwiye, who has been critical about debt-heavy loans imposed by Western institutions, has attracted some negative attention for her decision to implement strict fees and benefit-sharing rules regarding the carbon market.

DRAGO

CAREER HIGHLIGHTS

- **Minister of Environment**, Republic of Rwanda (2025 to present)
- **Senior Manager (Africa Restoration Programs)**, World Resources Institute (2023 to 2025)
- **Associate Manager**, World Resources Institute (2021 to 2023)
- **Research Associate,** World Resources Institute (2020 to 2021)
- **Research Associate,** Conservation International (2013 to 2014)
- **Research Assistant,** The Dian Fossey Gorilla Fund International (2009 to 2011)

BIO

Arakwiye's path from field researcher to cabinet minister overseeing environment policy speaks to her ability to translate science into nationwide impact. Born in Kigali circa 1985, she became spellbound by her country's natural beauty and the transformative power of fieldwork; on first sight of Volcanoes National Park, she exclaimed "I didn't know it was there! I thought I would be studying animals in labs."

- **Academic Acumen**
  Arakwiye reportedly graduated first in her class and was the top female science student at the University of Rwanda; her thesis was on "Positional Ecology of the Golden Monkey." She obtained an MA in Environmental Studies at Antioch University in New Hampshire and a PhD in Geography at Clark University in Massachusetts.

- **Naturalist Instinct**
  Arakwiye became enamored with field research, recalling that she was "very happy that walking all those kilometers was rewarded with good results" during the 2010 gorilla census. She has shared that she was inspired by the work of the early naturalists, specifically Alfred Russel Wallace and his maps of biogeographic distributions.

Arakwiye is married with two sons. She reportedly has a home in the scenic town of Musanze in northern Rwanda. While there is limited information about her religious beliefs, she sees faith communities as partners for climate and restoration programs, especially for local mobilization. The Minister speaks Kinyarwanda, English, and French.

OATH AFRICA 042916-5837

DRAGO

NOTES